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The Customer Outcome Pyramid

Five levels between a signed contract and a strategic partnership

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The Customer Outcome Pyramid

Level 1 -- Product Access

Have they adopted the product fully into their operations, or does it just sit unused after setup? At this level, the customer has purchased the product and completed technical setup -- accounts are created, integrations are configured, credentials work. That's it. This is the level most implementations stop at when a CSM measures success by whether the kickoff call happened, rather than whether anything changed for the customer afterward. Access is a precondition for value, not evidence of it.

Level 2 -- Product Adoption

Are the right people actually using the right features, regularly enough for it to matter? The customer is actively using the product's key features -- not every feature, and not necessarily often, but the ones that connect to the outcome they bought it for. This is where most vendor-side success metrics stop, and it's a mistake: a customer can be a model of Level 2 adoption and still churn, because usage alone has never paid a renewal invoice.

Level 3 -- Value Realization

Are they starting to see the specific benefit they expected -- time saved, cost reduced, a process that used to be slow now moving faster? The customer begins to experience measurable benefits, even if modest ones. This is the level where the relationship starts to become defensible, because there's now a real answer to "what has this actually done for us," rather than a description of what the product does.

Level 4 -- Business Outcomes

Are they achieving the results they originally set out to use the product to achieve -- the actual goal that justified the purchase in the first place? The customer's original goals are being achieved, not just approached. This is the level a renewal conversation should be built on, because it answers the only question that actually matters to a budget-holder: did this work?

Level 5 -- Strategic Partnership

Do they see you as someone worth calling before a decision is made, not just someone to contact when something breaks? The customer views the vendor as a trusted business partner and actively explores new opportunities for growth together. Very few accounts reach this level, and it's rarely won on product strength alone -- it's earned through a track record of the CSM consistently helping the customer think, not just helping them use software.

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About the Author

David Maika is a Customer Success professional with experience spanning customer operations, process improvement, CRM implementation, project management, and business strategy. His work focuses on helping organizations improve customer outcomes, strengthen operational efficiency, and build scalable systems that support long-term growth.

Through practical frameworks, real-world case studies, and modern AI-assisted workflows, he aims to make Customer Success knowledge accessible, actionable, and valuable for professionals at every stage of their careers.

To learn more, access additional resources, or connect professionally, visit davidmaika.com or linkedin.com/in/davidmaika.

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